

Chapter 32: The Woman Beside Him

The restaurant suddenly felt smaller.

Not because more people had entered.

Because of the woman standing beside Austin.

Jenny hated that she noticed her immediately.

The woman was beautiful.

Not in a dramatic way.

In an effortless way.

The kind of beauty that came with confidence, education, and a life where money had never been a daily concern.

Her dark coat probably cost more than Jenny earned in a month.

Maybe more.

Jenny forced herself to look away.

She was being ridiculous.

The woman was a customer.

Nothing more.

"Jenny."

Madam Chen's voice cut through her thoughts.

"Table seven."

Of course.

Table seven.

Jenny picked up a menu and walked toward them.

Professional.

Calm.

Controlled.

Years of customer service had taught her how to hide almost everything.

Almost.

When she reached the table, the woman smiled warmly.

"Good evening."

Jenny returned the smile.

"Good evening. Welcome."

Austin remained silent.

Which was unusual.

Normally he would have said something by now.

A comment.

A greeting.

Anything.

Instead, he looked tired.

The woman glanced at him before returning her attention to Jenny.

"We'll need a few minutes."

"Of course."

Jenny turned to leave.

Then stopped when she heard the woman speak again.

"So this is the place."

Jenny kept walking.

But every instinct sharpened.

Ten minutes later, she returned for their order.

The woman closed the menu.

"I'll have the seafood noodles."

Jenny wrote it down.

"And for you, sir?"

Austin barely looked at the menu.

"The usual."

Jenny nodded.

For some reason, that familiar answer made her chest tighten.

The woman noticed.

Or maybe Jenny imagined it.

Either way, the woman smiled slightly.

"You come here often?"

Austin finally spoke.

"Yes."

"Very often?"

"Yes."

The woman laughed softly.

"I can see that."

Jenny finished writing.

"Your order will be ready shortly."

She walked away before anyone could say anything else.

Bao appeared beside her almost immediately.

"Who's the woman?"

Jenny kept her eyes on the order pad.

"I don't know."

"You want to know."

"I don't."

"You absolutely do."

Jenny shot him a look.

Bao grinned.

"Interesting."

"Go away."

"No."

The rest of the evening felt strange.

The woman and Austin spoke quietly.

Too quietly for Jenny to hear.

But she noticed things anyway.

The familiarity between them.

The ease.

The history.

Not romantic.

At least not obviously.

But definitely not strangers.

That bothered her more than she wanted to admit.

At one point, the woman excused herself to take a phone call.

The moment she left the table, Austin looked up.

Directly at Jenny.

Like he had been waiting.

Jenny tried to ignore him.

Failed.

Eventually, she approached.

"You need anything?"

Austin studied her face.

"No."

A pause.

Then—

"You look upset."

Jenny almost laughed.

"You're imagining things."

"No."

There it was again.

That annoying certainty.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Your friend seems nice."

The moment the words left her mouth, she regretted them.

Too personal.

Too interested.

Too obvious.

Austin noticed immediately.

Of course he did.

"Friend?"

Jenny shrugged.

"Whatever she is."

For the first time that evening, something almost resembling amusement appeared in his eyes.

"Her name is Victoria."

Jenny hated how much she disliked hearing that name.

"Okay."

A pause.

Then Austin asked quietly,

"Do you want to know who she is?"

"No."

The answer came too fast.

Austin's expression changed.

Just slightly.

Enough.

"You're lying."

Jenny sighed.

"You haven't seen me for two days and this is what you want to talk about?"

The words escaped before she could stop them.

Silence followed.

Both of them noticed what she'd accidentally revealed.

You haven't seen me for two days.

Not *I haven't seen you*.

Austin's gaze softened immediately.

Dangerously.

"Jenny."

She looked away.

"Forget it."

But Austin didn't.

For once, he looked almost pleased.

And that irritated her even more.

Victoria returned before the conversation could continue.

She sat down gracefully.

Her eyes moved between them.

Observant.

Intelligent.

Noticing more than she said.

Jenny excused herself quickly.

Back to work.

Back to safety.

Near closing time, Victoria approached the counter alone.

Jenny was organizing receipts.

"Excuse me."

Jenny looked up.

Victoria smiled politely.

"I wanted to compliment the food."

"Thank you."

"The service too."

"Thank you."

A brief silence followed.

Then Victoria said something unexpected.

"You're important to him."

Jenny froze.

Only for a second.

But Victoria saw it.

The older woman smiled gently.

Not cruelly.

Not mockingly.

Almost sympathetically.

"I've known Austin for years."

Jenny said nothing.

Victoria continued.

"I've never seen him like this."

The restaurant suddenly felt too quiet.

Too still.

Jenny forced her voice to remain professional.

"I think you misunderstand."

Victoria shook her head.

"No."

A pause.

Then softly—

"I don't."

Before Jenny could respond, Austin appeared beside them.

"Victoria."

The woman looked at him.

"We should go."

Austin's expression revealed nothing.

But Victoria smiled.

Like she understood something neither of them had admitted yet.

As they reached the door, Austin stopped.

He turned toward Jenny.

The same way he always did before leaving.

Only this time, Victoria was watching.

The outside world was watching.

And suddenly their private routine didn't feel private anymore.

Austin held her gaze for a moment.

Then said quietly,

"I'll see you tomorrow."

The words were simple.

Familiar.

Ordinary.

Yet somehow, with Victoria standing beside him, they felt different.

More exposed.

More real.

Jenny nodded.

Unable to trust her voice.

Austin left.

Victoria followed.

But just before exiting, she glanced back one last time.

And smiled.

Like someone who already knew a story's direction.

Even when the people inside it didn't.

End of Chapter 32 ❤️